



EDUCATION

CAMPUS IMPROVEMENT

VISD targets gains at struggling campuses

JAKOB GURLEY

Victoria Independent School District officials outlined ongoing improvement efforts Thursday for campuses facing state accountability interventions, pointing to gains at priority schools, increased instructional support and changes to the district's middle school match sequence.

Jake Salcines, chief of secondary schools, and Tammy Garza, chief of elementary schools, presented the update to the VISD Board of Trustees. Patti Welder Elementary School is in its third year of school improvement, while STEM Middle School is in its second. Both campuses are implementing turnaround plans approved in November 2025.

Salcines said both campuses have made significant gains during the past two years and are trending in the right direction.

"We are getting out this year," Salcines said, referring to the district's goal of moving the campuses out of school improvement status.

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Patti Welder Elementary School is implementing a turnaround plan that includes additional instructional support, teacher planning time and intervention strategies. (Jakob Gurley/Victoria Advocate)

District officials said an F rating can add another year to the school improvement process, while three consecutive D ratings can result in a campus dropping another rating level. By the fifth year, state intervention, including the possible appointment of a board of managers or campus closure, can become a consideration.

The turnaround plans include teacher stipends, additional planning and lesson-internalization time, intervention classes and "power

sections" during the school day. VISD also has increased campus support through weekly professional learning communities, principal coaching and classroom visits.

Salcines said the district is using State Board of Education-approved high-quality instructional materials while ensuring teachers have adequate time to prepare and internalize lessons.

VISD also brought in outside consultants to assist with improvement efforts. Arla Chapa, a retired administrator

with 38 years of experience, is working primarily with Patti Welder. Tammy Sestak, who has experience in data analysis and familiarity with the district, also was brought in to provide support.

The district also is changing its middle school math sequence. Seventh-grade math is being phased out, with seventh graders moving into eighth-grade math. During the transition, eighth graders also will take eighth-grade math.

SEE CAMPUS, A5



Victoria ISD school board President Rick Jones listens during a Thursday board meeting as district officials discuss ongoing school improvement efforts at campuses facing state accountability interventions. (Jakob Gurley/Victoria Advocate)

GOVERNMENT

Victoria approves police, fire technology upgrades

ALEXANDRA PASHAYER

Victoria City Council approved multimillion-dollar technology agreements Tuesday aimed at upgrading police equipment, evidence processing, emergency dispatch and fire station alerting systems.

During its Sept. 15 meeting, the council approved a five-year agreement with Axon Enterprise Inc., formerly TASER International, for equipment and software used by the Victoria Police Department.

Victoria police have used Axon Tasers, body-worn cameras, in-car cameras and the company's Evidence.com digital evidence platform for about 12 years.

The new agreement adds Axon's Redaction Assistant, which automates portions of the process used to obscure faces, license plates, computer screens and audio in video evidence.

Police Capt. Kevin Sanderson, who presented the item in place of Police Chief Clay Fetters, said the software could significantly reduce the time required to process video evidence. The system can process multiple pieces of video evidence simultaneously, potentially reducing the processing time for two hours of video to less than 10 minutes.

Axon is expected to provide the department with 130 Redaction Assistant user licenses beginning Nov. 1. The licenses would be provided at no cost during the first year, with the city beginning payments in the second year.

The agreement also includes body-worn cameras, upgraded Tasers, cameras and microphones for police interview rooms and a virtual reality training system designed to help officers practice de-escalating nonlethal situations.

"My agenda says Clay Fetters, but you aren't Clay Fetters. Good to see you again," Mayor Duane

Crocker told Sanderson. "The chief had a speaking engagement at a first responder banquet this evening, so I'm filling in," Sanderson said.

"So he owes you a steak dinner; is that how that works?" Crocker joked, drawing laughter.

The council also approved a five-year, \$3.5 million agreement with Motorola Solutions to modernize technology used by the city's police and fire departments.

Information Technology Director James Foote said the Motorola system would integrate computer-aided dispatch, records management, mapping and analytics into a single platform. It also includes geographic situational awareness, anonymous tip submission and camera registration capabilities.

The agreement also would replace aging alerting equipment at six Victoria fire stations. Payments will be spread over three years without interest, Foote said.

"Motorola also assigns a dedicated customer success team from day one," Foote said.

Other council action

The council also approved the creation of a municipal stormwater drainage utility system. The associated drainage fee will take effect Jan. 1 and provide dedicated funding for drainage maintenance and improvements.

Council members approved a roughly \$82,514 contract for trail improvements at Ted B. Reed Park and a \$507,614 contract for landscaping at city properties.

The council also appointed Donna Roberts to the Victoria Public Library Advisory Board and reappointed Gay Patek and Catherine Olson. Their terms expire Sept. 30, 2029.

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■ WEATHER

TODAY

A couple of afternoon t-storms; hot

96

TONIGHT

Clear and humid

71

■ GAS PRICES

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